



Genius Look 313 Media
The Swiss army knife of the webcams



Features

The Logitech QuickCam Notebook Pro and Microsoft LifeCam NX-6000 are meant to be used with laptops. They come with carry pouches. The Logitech QuickCam Notebook Pro also has a 12-inch, sturdy stand, making it Desktop-friendly as well. The Microsoft LifeCam NX-6000 and VX-6000 provide a call switch for Live! Messenger, but miss out on a snapshot button.

The Clamp

The clamping mechanism for laptops is better in the case of the Microsoft VX-6000 than that of the Logitech QuickCam Notebook, but the Microsoft's clamp is not wide enough to work with laptop that have thicker tops. The spring-based, hinged mechanism of the Creative Live! Cam Optia allows it to be clamped to any LCD with ease. The Logitech QuickCam Pro 5000 implements a flexible base instead of a clamping mechanism, which allows easy adaptability to any LCD panel.

Enhancements

All the webcams here support face tracking, except for the Microsoft NX-6000. The

Performance

In Daylight

The snaps we took with the Logitech QuickCam IM had the best contrast here, with richer natural colour reproduction. Excessively high-contrast images by the Creative Live! Pro meant the captured frames were poor. The Genius Look 313 Media was better. The Genius Look 310S doesn't match up to the competition—capture quality was not up to the mark.

In Fluorescent Light

The Genius Look 313 Media's capture quality was good, but the Logitech QuickCam IM produced better contrast ratio. The Creative Live! IM pro was the better performer of the rest, with the Microsoft VX-3000 missing out largely on sharpness and slightly in brightness levels. The Genius 310S colour reproduction was below par, missing out on natural colour tones.

THE NICHE CATEGORY

Cameras above Rs 3,000 have features like motorised swivel, face tracking, and better capture quality at higher resolutions. Software like Muvee Auto Producer bundled with the Creative Live! Cam Optia provides features rich enough for authoring home videos, but the short USB cable hampers free movement and usability as a camcorder.

We reviewed six contenders in this category. Three were from Logitech. Microsoft sports two products, and Creative, one.



Creative Live! Cam Optia
Rock solid performance that gels with its looks

Minimise Webcam Niggles!

If you already own a webcam or are on your way to becoming one soon, here are some lighting tips to help you get the best possible images from your webcam. Lighting plays an important role in any image, as in highlighting the subject more than the background.

- ☐ Webcams are generally placed on top of LCD or CRT monitors, with the light falling directly on the face of the subject (the monitors act as light sources). Faces will reflect the colour of the window on the Desktop, and spectacles (if any) will have reflections on them as well. The solution is obvious—reduce the brightness and contrast of the monitor and dim the lights in the room.
- ☐ Use a table lamp to highlight the subject. The bright light causes the webcam to lower its exposure, dropping background objects a little. If the table light turns to be too bright or harsh, use typing or butter paper to cover the mouth

of the table lamp so as to soften the light. Adjust the background lights again; if possible, turn them off completely. The light reflected off the walls and close-by objects due to the table lamp will help.

- ☐ If your face tends to change colour or tone during a webcam session, that's the webcam's white balance / auto-exposure at work. Tackling this is simple: wear white clothing! The prominence of white in foreground further reduces the effect of background light.
- ☐ Getting a backdrop helps greatly, though it can be expensive. One can even use curtains as the backdrop, just as an alternative. A grey backdrop is best suited for the purpose.
- ☐ Don't get too close to the monitor while typing. A relaxed sitting posture not only looks better, it also helps the soft light of the table lamp bounce off all of your face, thereby producing a clearer image.